



Watchful Philippines gets closer to Taiwan

Amid clashes with China at sea, Manila ramps up engagement with Taipei

BY REBECCA TAN, FRANCES MANGOSING AND PEI-LIN WU

MANILA — Faced with intensifying Chinese encroachment at sea, the Philippines increasingly sees its national security as intertwined with that of Taiwan and is quietly ramping up both formal and informal engagement with the self-governing island, including on security, according to government officials, defense analysts and diplomats here.

This marks a significant departure from Manila's conservative approach toward Taiwan and could pave the way for the Philippines, a U.S. treaty ally, to play a bigger role if China makes good on its threats to invade Taiwan.

"Any force projection of China within our area is a matter of extreme concern," Philippine Defense Secretary Gilbert Teodoro said in a recent interview.

While Manila still observes the one-China policy stipulating that there is only one Chinese government — the People's Republic of China — the fates of the Philippines and Taiwan are increasingly enmeshed, he said.

"It would be hiding from the obvious to say that Taiwan's security will not affect us," added Teodoro, who recently endorsed a Japanese proposal to view the East China Sea, the South China Sea and the Korean Peninsula as a single "theater" of battle.

China and the Philippines have clashed with rising intensity in

SEE TAIWAN ON A12

Authors fight back as AI guzzles their bibliographies

BY WILL OREMUS

David Baldacci, the author of best-selling legal thrillers, watched his son ask ChatGPT to craft a plot in the style of a David Baldacci novel. Within five seconds, he told U.S. senators at a hearing last week on artificial intelligence and copyright, the chatbot spat out a pastiche of characters, settings and plot twists that were uncannily familiar.

"It truly felt like someone had backed up a truck to my imagination and stolen everything I'd ever created," he said.

Baldacci is among a group of authors suing OpenAI and Microsoft over the companies' use of their work to train the AI software behind tools such as ChatGPT and Copilot without permission or payment — one of more than 40 lawsuits against AI companies advancing through the nation's courts. He and other authors last week appealed to Congress for help standing up to what they see as an assault by Big Tech on their profession and the soul of literature.

They found sympathetic ears at a Senate subcommittee hearing Wednesday, where lawmakers expressed outrage at the technology industry's practices. Their cause gained further momentum Thursday when a federal judge

SEE AI ON A2



JESSE BARBER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Natalie Newman's new home is filled with items she had to replace after Hurricane Helene swept away the building where she lived.

A new era of inland flooding has arrived

Devastation in western N.C., Texas Hill Country is signal to rethink disaster plans, experts say

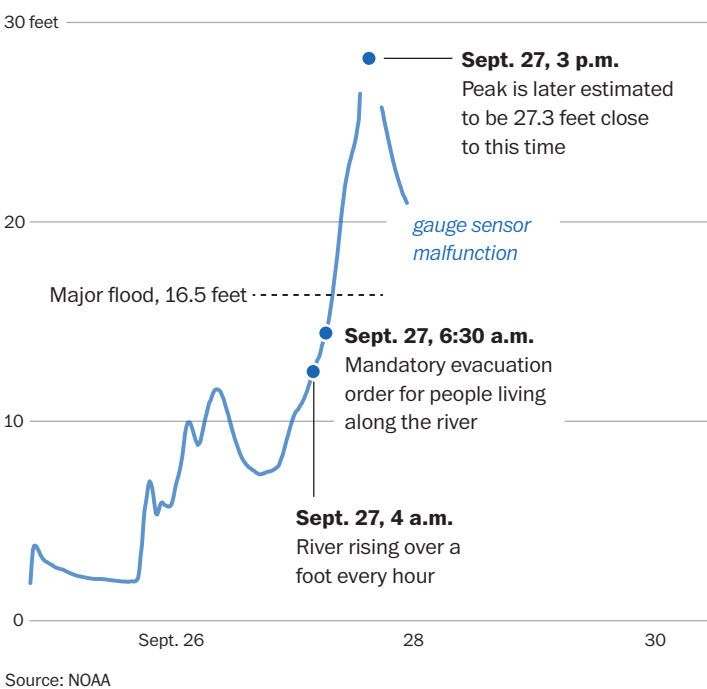
BY SARAH KAPLAN, KEVIN CROWE, NAEMA AHMED AND BEN NOLL

Natalie Newman believed she had done everything she could to get ready for Helene.

Before the hurricane carved a path of destruction across the Southeast in late September, she assumed it would be like other storms she had experienced in five years of living in Asheville, North Carolina. So Newman took her usual precautions: packing a go-bag, stocking up on food, moving her car uphill from her apartment on the banks of the Swannanoa River.

When Newman's phone buzzed with a flash-flood warning the night before the storm hit, she skimmed the text: "This is a dangerous and life-threatening situation. Do not attempt to travel unless you are fleeing an area subject to flooding or under an evacuation order." Then the artist returned to

The Swannanoa River at the Biltmore estate in Asheville



the painting she was working on.

The river was still at least 20 feet below her second-story apartment, and she had not received an evacuation order. If her home was no longer safe, Newman thought, surely officials would tell her to leave.

But no order would come before the deadly floodwaters arrived at her door.

From last year's disaster in Asheville to this month's catastrophic floods in Central Texas, the world has entered a new era of rainfall supercharged by climate change, rendering existing response plans inadequate. A Washington Post analysis of atmospheric data found a record amount of moisture flowing in the skies over the past year and a half, largely due to rising global temperatures. With so much warm, moist air available as fuel, storms are increasingly able to move water vapor from the oceans to locations hundreds of miles from the coast,

SEE HELENE ON A6

Massacre reveals breakdown of order in Sudan war

At least 31 were killed when paramilitary fighters attacked a civilian convoy, a Post reconstruction shows

BY KATHARINE HOURELD, HAFIZ HAROUN AND CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN IN SALHA, SUDAN

The families had pooled their money for the convoy, hoping to escape the battle for the final piece of the Sudanese capital in late April. They had just set off when paramilitary gunmen shot out their tires at a roadblock, survivors said. The men were forced out, they recalled, then the fighters threatened to set the trucks on fire with the women and children inside.

"Everyone was crying and screaming," said Amal Ismail, 30, holding tightly to her son, a wide-eyed boy of 10. "We could see our husbands and brothers being beaten outside."

Soon, the killing began.

At least 31 people were massacred on April 27 in Salha, a neighborhood in the city of Omdurman, across the Nile from the capital, Khartoum, survivors said. Drawing on eight eyewitness accounts and videos, as well as evidence gathered from the scene, The

SEE SUDAN ON A10



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Motasim Salih, a member of the Sudanese armed forces, patrols a street in Omdurman, Sudan, in late May, days after the country's military retook the area from the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces.

Frequent flouting of judges' orders

DEFIANCE BY TRUMP IN 1 IN 3 COURT CASES

Pattern of conduct poses threat to legal system

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

President Donald Trump and his appointees have been accused of flouting courts in a third of the more than 160 lawsuits against the administration in which a judge has issued a substantive ruling, a Washington Post analysis has found, suggesting widespread noncompliance with America's legal system.

Plaintiffs say Justice Department lawyers and the agencies they represent are snubbing rulings, providing false information, failing to turn over evidence, quietly working around court orders and inventing pretexts to carry out actions that have been blocked.

Judges appointed by presidents of both parties have often agreed. None have taken punitive action to try to force compliance, however, allowing the administration's defiance of orders to go on for weeks or even months in some instances.

Outside legal analysts say courts typically are slow to begin contempt proceedings for non-compliance, especially while their rulings are under appeal. Judges also are likely to be concerned, analysts say, that the U.S. Marshals Service — whose director is appointed by the president — might not serve subpoenas or take recalcitrant government officials

SEE TRUMP ON A8

How MAGA media upped pressure over Epstein files

BY SARAH ELLISON

When conservative podcaster Liz Wheeler visited the White House along with other MAGA influencers on Feb. 27, Attorney General Pam Bondi handed her a binder labeled "The Epstein Files: Phase 1." Wheeler hoped the contents might be the first step toward finally getting to the bottom of the deceased sex offender's elite inner circle and who else might have been involved in wrongdoing.

But much to her frustration, the binders mainly contained previously released material. Recently, as a heated national debate over the Epstein files erupted, Wheeler's phone was blowing up with associates asking her why the administration brought the group to the White House in the first place. This month, Wheeler has been using her platform on "The Liz Wheeler Show" to lambaste Bondi and accuse her of misrepresenting the Epstein files to gain fame on Fox News.

"I am speaking for the base here, and that the base associates the Epstein files now with justice," Wheeler said in a recent interview with The Washington Post. "People feel like there's been something hidden from them, which triggers people and rightfully so."

SEE EPSTEIN ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Scottie Scheffler soars After he cruises to the title at the British Open, it's clear that the top-ranked American golfer has no peer, columnist Barry Svrluga writes. C1

How we got here A timeline of events in the tangled battle between President Donald Trump and Harvard University. A4

THE NATION Trump has built an unusually fraught relationship with his presidential predecessors. A3
A U.S. citizen who works for the Commerce Department was snared in a Chinese exit ban. A5

The number of missing in the Texas floods dropped from almost 100 to three. A8

THE WORLD Residents of a Nigerian town have suffered since a fuel subsidy ended. A9

THE ECONOMY A global hack against Microsoft's popular SharePoint software exploited a security flaw and disrupted government agencies and corporations. A13
The Coldplay kiss cam incident is proof that viral clips stoke the public's zeal for shame. A13

STYLE Stephen Colbert's cancellation highlighted a long shift in the power dynamics of late-night television. B1

SPORTS A Chinese center who was a surprise draft pick of the Portland Trail Blazers became the NBA's summer star. C1

THE REGION Overdoses in a Baltimore neighborhood may be linked to a dangerous new drug. C7

HEALTH & SCIENCE The Amish are particularly immune to seasonal allergies that affect the rest of us, leading scientists to try to find out why. D1

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